Shah Jehan succeeded Jehangir in 1628. The name Shah Jehan means ‘King of the World’ in Persian, and his reign was the golden age of Mughal architecture. Many edifices small and great, including the Taj Mahal, were built under him. He also decided to move the capital back to Delhi and build a new city in 1639. The city would be called Shahjehanabad after himself, although we now know it as Old Delhi. Completed in 1648, it had twenty-seven towers, eleven gates and a population of around 400,000. Shah Jehan had chosen a site that was farther north of the existing city, the northernmost Delhi yet. It contained a walled palace-complex surrounded by walls of red Dholpur sandstone—what we call the Red Fort. For lesser buildings, material was scavenged from the older Delhis, especially Dinpanah and Feroze Shah Kotla. The Red Fort was built along the river and, during the monsoon, water would have flowed along the palace walls. However, most of the time there was a ‘beach’ between the river’s edge and the fort where elephant-fights and other events were organized for the entertainment of the court.

It is not easy to see the original layout of Shahjehanabad by merely visiting Old Delhi because the city has gone through many changes over the centuries. Nonetheless, one can still discern many of the key features. There was a straight and wide avenue that began at the Red Fort’s western gate and ran through the main bazaar to one of the city’s main gates. It remains as Chandni Chowk, named after the way the full moon once reflected on a canal that ran along the middle of the road.

The French traveller Bernier visited the city a few decades after it was completed and has left us a detailed eyewitness account[16]. One of the first things that struck Bernier was that the fortifications of both the city and the Red Fort were old-fashioned and not designed to withstand artillery. He states, ‘Considerable as these works may appear, their real strength is by no means great and in my opinion a battery of moderate force would soon level them to the ground’. It is unclear why Shah Jehan opted for designs that were already considered outdated in the mid-seventeenth century. Perhaps the empire felt so secure that he did not feel it necessary to build for a military siege. Perhaps, it is just another example of the increasing